

Miller Leaves Empty Hole

Miner Baseball Team Works Toward Opener

By MARK LEIBSON
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Baseball season for The University of Texas at El Paso hasn't even started yet and already, Manager Andy Cohen is confronted with a serious problem.

Seems last summer, second baseman Mark Miller was involved in a baseball program in the Dallas area and he caught the eye of the Texas Rangers.

Before Miller returned to El Paso, the Rangers made sure Miller's career with the Miners was finished. Texas signed the slick-fielding Eastwood High School graduate to a professional baseball contract and next month, Miller will be

heading toward spring training instead of swinging a bat for U.T. El Paso.

"Dam, I hate to lose Miller," said Cohen Tuesday as he starts his 13th year at the helm. "Miller is a great ball player and I was counting on him heavily."

But, that's the way of life and Cohen knows it.

So, as the Miners workout towards the start of the season—Feb. 14 and 15th with doubleheaders against Texas Tech at Dudley Field, Cohen must find a replacement for Miller at second.

"There's going to be a tough battle for secondbase between Art Bravo, Terry Hudson and Alan Morris, a graduate from

Eastwood who transferred from Davis Junior College," said Cohen. Bravo is a freshman right out of Austin High School while Morris ranks a junior in classification.

While the diamondmen worked out at Hugh Meyer Field on their hitting, Cohen was predicting an improved team from last season's 24-26 squad which also posted a 2-16 Western Athletic Conference mark.

"We should have a better all around ball club," Cohen prognosticated. "Our defense is just as good and if our pitching comes around, we should be doing all right. Pitching is going to have to carry us this year."

Two hurlers Cohen is counting on to fill some big shoes are a pair of lefthanders in George Landreth from Ranger JC and freshman Ron Wrobel, a 17-year-old from Chicago. Says Cohen, "They're both tremendous prospects and they could be what we're looking for to improve our pitching staff."

Cohen has a fine corp of returning fielders in third baseman Glenn Villarreal, Terry Dillingham at first and Joe Pennies roaming around in center field.

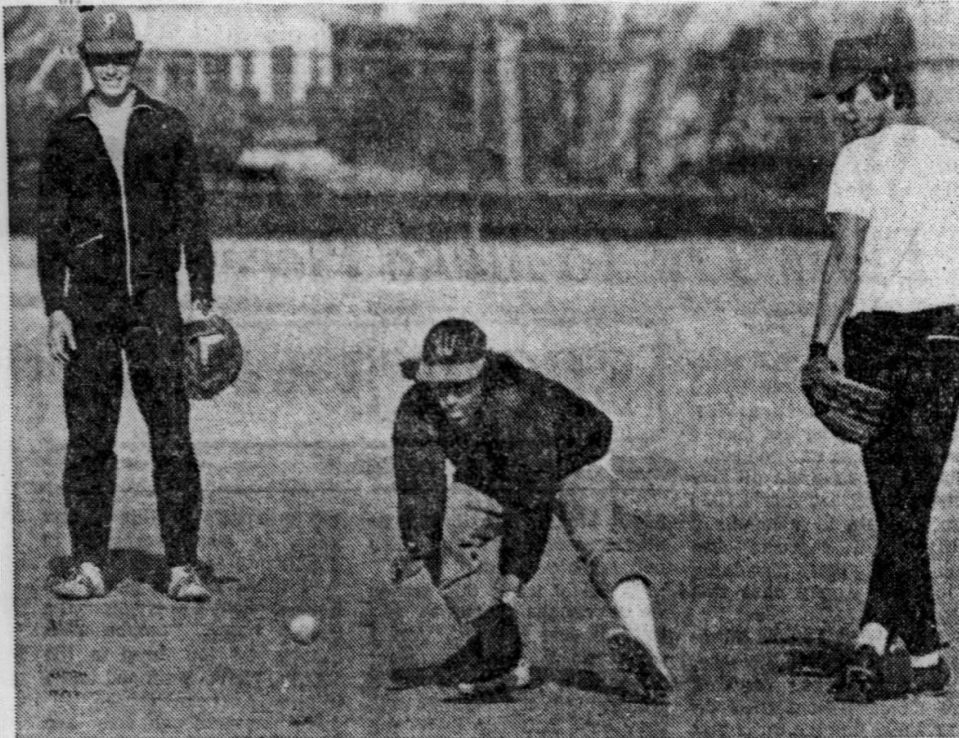
Villarreal, as well as Pennies, played in all 51 of the Miner games and accumulated .383 and .323 batting averages respectively. Dillingham only saw action in 39 contests but was the third leading hitter with a .324 average with four homeruns. He also led U.T. El Paso with a .987 fielding percentage.

"Both Glen and Joe Pennies have improved steadily and I feel that both players are professional prospects," praised Cohen. "Dillingham will also be a big asset to our team."

Dillingham could see competition from John Hahn, a 240-pound center for U.T. El Paso during the football season. The big catcher-first baseman is determined to become a starter and with all that weight behind his swing, Cohen might not have to think twice about sticking Hahn into the lineup.

Other returning starters include shortstop Dave Nance, a walk on who never played baseball before joining the Miners last season, Jimmy Walsh, a right fielder who hails out of Burges and Keith Rushing who plays both left and right field.

Three pitchers counted on to pace U.T. El Paso include Bob Knox (3-4), Jeff Hogan (3-5), Dan Modlinski (3-6) and Roy Stringer (6-5). Stringer held the best earned run average in 1974 with a 4.78 mark.



MINERS AT PRACTICE — Baseball season has already started at The University of Texas at El Paso and the biggest war launched so far is the battle for second base vacated by Texas Ranger-bound Mark Miller. Art Bravo, a freshman from Austin High School, stoops to pick up a grounder while other candidates Allan Morris, right, and Terry Hudson await their turn. The season begins Feb. 14 against Texas Tech at Dudley Field.

—(Photo by Luis Villalobos)